CLEAN ENERGY ACTION COALITION | BATTERY STORAGE BRIEFING

Battery Storage in Westchester: What Local Leaders Should Know

The evidence, the rules and the local track record, drawn from the CEAC Battery Storage Dashboard. Updated October 2026.

Prepared for the **Westchester County Battery Energy Storage Conference** | Monday, October 19, 2026 | Westchester County Center, White Plains

99% lower

incident rate for grid batteries since 2018, while U.S. grid storage grew about 50 times over. (EPRI, EIA)

0

civilian deaths or injuries from U.S. grid battery incidents, 2012 to 2024. (EPRI incident records)

15 months

for a grid battery to pay back the carbon from its manufacture on today's Westchester grid. (EPA eGRID, NREL)

209 homes

One Tesla Megapack can supply about 209 New York homes for a day, and fits in about one parking space.

ALREADY WORKING HERE

Three community batteries of about 4 to 5 MW each have operated in Westchester since 2025: two on church land (St. Augustine in Ossining and Hawthorne Reformed Church) and one behind a garage in Yorktown, on sites that were already developed.

Tarrytown's Planning Board approved a 20 MWh battery 4 to 0 in September 2025, with 100 ft setbacks and 200 ft from any home.

SAFETY RULES ARE IN PLACE

- The 2025 Fire Code of New York State took effect December 31, 2025. Its battery rules follow NFPA 855, the national standard, which spaces equipment using large-scale fire tests.
- Westchester County's 2025 law requires municipalities to notify the County of every battery site, so responders know where they are.
- Over 90% of new stationary storage in 2025 used LFP batteries, a steadier chemistry with no cobalt or nickel.
- Free state training for fire departments is available from NYS DHSES and can be hosted locally.

HOW MUCH ROOM STORAGE NEEDS

The batteries themselves are compact. What uses land is the setback a town sets. Tarrytown, Ossining and Greenburgh each require 100 ft, which keeps about 1.55 acres clear around a Tarrytown-size site. NYSERDA's model law lets larger systems meet the setbacks a zoning district already sets for buildings.

WHERE WESTCHESTER'S 45 MUNICIPALITIES STAND

- **13** allow battery storage
- **9** have a restrictive code
- **15** have no battery code yet
- **5** have a moratorium
- **3** ban it

From the CEAC Live Policy Tracker, last updated September 22, 2026. Look up any town's rules, contacts and next meeting online.

CLEANER AIR, FROM START TO FINISH

Batteries take the place of gas peaker plants that run on the hottest days, often in dense neighborhoods. In New York City, peakers produce up to 94% of the city's nitrogen oxide emissions on the worst smog days, and 750,000 New Yorkers live within a mile of one. A battery burns nothing on site.

New York's model law asks owners to keep a bond for the life of the site, so removal and restoration are paid for before construction starts.

SEE IT FOR YOURSELF

Scan for the full dashboard

starrysidekick.github.io/CEAC-Dashboard

Live Policy Tracker, Successful Projects, Model Law, Key Considerations, Your Electric Bill, Fire & Safety, Size & Setbacks, Risk in Context, Life Cycle and the Resource Center. A countywide Clean Energy Map is coming soon.

Clean Energy Action Coalition, The Business Council of Westchester, with EarthKind Energy. Every figure above is sourced on the matching dashboard page (EPRI, U.S. EIA, PHMSA, NYS Department of State, NYSERDA, EPA eGRID 2023, NREL, IEA).

BESS RESOURCE GUIDE

Where to go next: trusted sources for boards, staff and responders

Every item comes from a government agency, a university, a federally funded national laboratory or an independent research organization. Starred items are the best place to start.

START WITH THE BASICS

General education for residents and officials

★ **Battery Energy Storage: What New Yorkers Should Know**, NYSERDA. A brief primer on the whys and hows of energy storage, written for residents.

Battery Energy Storage: Information for You and Your Constituents, NYSERDA. The same primer, pitched at local officials fielding constituent questions.

PERMITTING AND ZONING

If you are writing or updating a local law

★ **NYS Battery Energy Storage System Guidebook for Local Governments**, NYSERDA. The core toolkit: permitting steps, SEQR, setbacks and decommissioning, updated February 2026.

Battery Energy Storage System Model Law, NYSERDA. Adaptable zoning text for Tier 1 and Tier 2 systems.

Battery Energy Storage System Model Permit, NYSERDA. A fill-in permit application and checklist a building department can adopt as is.

Battery Energy Storage System FAQ, NYSERDA. Fifty plus plain-language answers, built for public hearings.

Principles and Options for Designing BESS Zoning Ordinances, Pacific Northwest National Laboratory. A 2026 national survey of how towns have written their battery rules.

Solar and BESS Potential Sites Map, Columbia University students, shared by Sustainable Westchester. An interactive 2025 map of where solar and battery projects could fit across Westchester.

WESTCHESTER COUNTY REQUIREMENTS

What is required here

★ **Lithium-Ion Battery Safety and the BESS Notification Program**, Westchester County Dept. of Emergency Services. How a municipality complies with the County's 2025 notification law.

BESS Notification Form, Westchester County Dept. of Emergency Services. The form municipalities submit under the law.

Westchester County Code, Chapter 637, Section 637.03, Westchester County. The statutory text of the notification requirement.

SAFETY, CODE AND RESPONSE

For code enforcement, fire officials and responders

★ **BESS Fire Service Response Guide**, NYS DHSES, Office of Fire Prevention and Control. A one-page tactical field guide for responding crews.

Battery Emergencies and Electrical Storage Systems training, NYS DHSES. Free state training for first responders, which can be hosted at your own department.

Energy Storage Trainings for Local Governments, NYSERDA. Upcoming and recorded webinars, including sessions for code officials.

2025 Fire Code of New York State, Section 1207, NYS Department of State. The enforceable rules, free and in full. In effect since December 31, 2025.

Guide to Battery Energy Storage System Safety, Electric Power Research Institute. An introductory guide to fire safety considerations.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

When you are asked hard questions

★ **Air, Soil and Water Data Findings**, NYS Inter-Agency Fire Safety Working Group. Independent testing after New York's 2023 incidents found no significant contamination beyond the sites.

Fire Code Recommendations Report, NYS Inter-Agency Fire Safety Working Group. What the state changed and why. These recommendations became the 2025 code.

Insights from EPRI's BESS Failure Incident Database, Electric Power Research Institute. Most past incidents traced to controls and wiring, and the rate has fallen sharply since 2018.

WHERE TO GET HELP

You do not have to do this alone

★ **NYSERDA Clean Energy Siting Team**, NYSERDA. Free one-to-one help for municipalities: cleanenergyhelp@nyserda.ny.gov.

Land Use Technical Assistance, Pace University Land Use Law Center. Zoning code analysis and community education, fee for service: (914) 422-4034.

Sustainable Westchester, Sustainable Westchester. Municipal energy programs and support across the county's member communities.

CEAC Battery Storage Dashboard and Live Policy Tracker, Clean Energy Action Coalition, BCW. Where every Westchester municipality stands, plus the evidence pages summarized on the front.

Links checked October 2026. Clickable in the PDF; the same list lives in the dashboard's Resource Center: starrysidekick.github.io/CEAC-Dashboard/resources.html